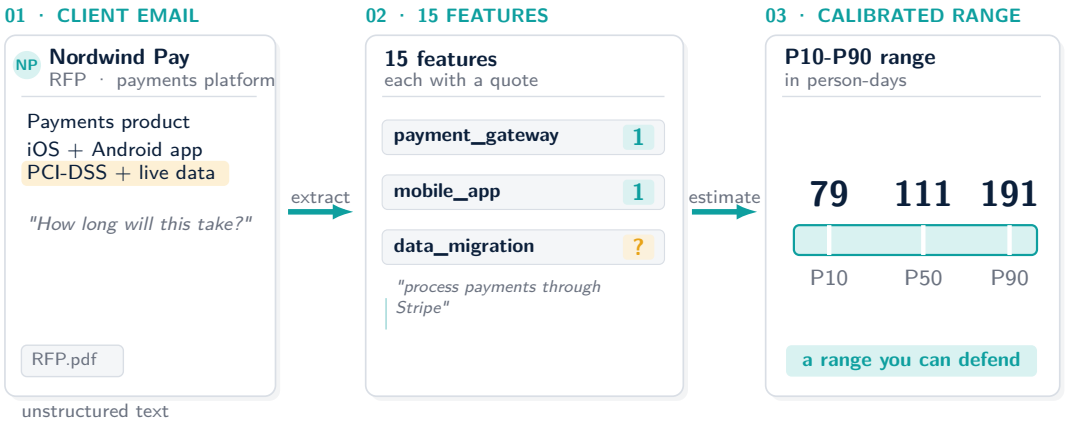
THE ESTIMATOR

A project estimate that shows its evidence.

Nguyen My Thong · AI Business Operations · Anduin



NP **Nordwind Pay** 09:14
Subject: Payments platform RFP

Hi, we need a payments product
for a mobile app on iOS and Android.
It requires PCI-DSS certification
and live updates on a dashboard.
No multi-currency for now.

Elena Voss, Nordwind Pay

RFP_2026.pdf

How many days?

?

2 hours reading | 3 clarifying questions | **still a guess**

LLM-only: 258 days off. Five runs, one answer; the error is calibration.

LLM-only

258

days error
last 42 projects

The Estimator

19

days error
same 42 projects

no history | no calibration | no evidence | **missing info = guess**

The fastest design had no audit trail. I chose the slower one.

A LLM end-to-end ✗

reads + estimates

- fast
- no audit
- no calibration

rejected

B LLM + rules ~

extract + rules

- auditable
- brittle
- no learning

trade-off

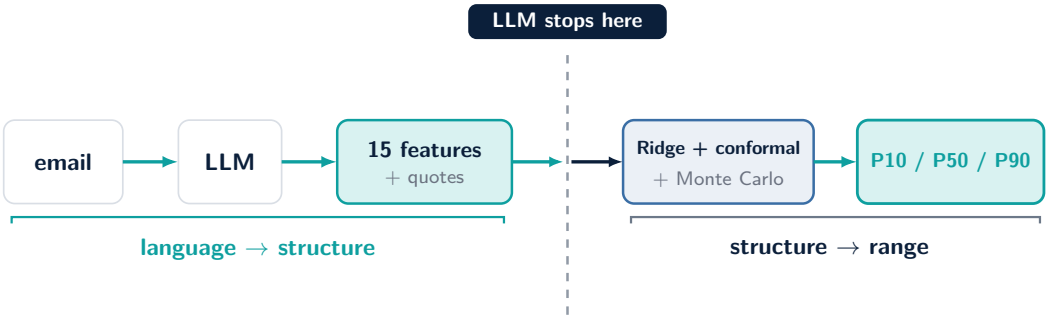
C LLM + math ✓

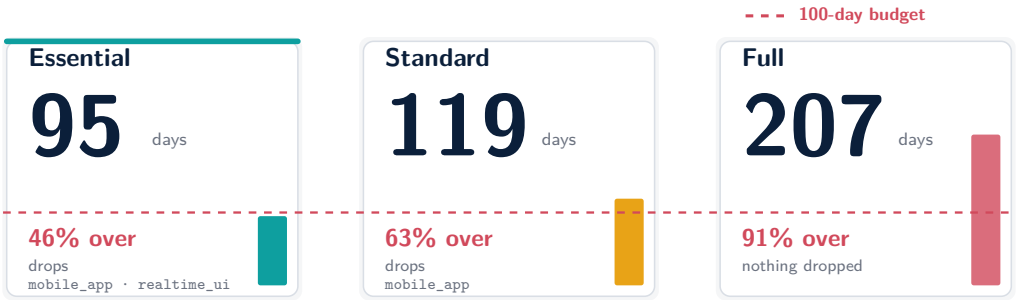
extract only → math

- auditable
- calibrated
- learns

chosen

Every field carries a quote; silence widens the range instead of guessing.





Essential: renegotiate budget or timeline.

Walk-forward on 218 steps: half the team's error, 86.7% coverage, five negative results published.

17.36
days error vs 32.93



86.7%
coverage 189/218



0.933
extraction quality



$0.20
for 240 emails



242 offline tests

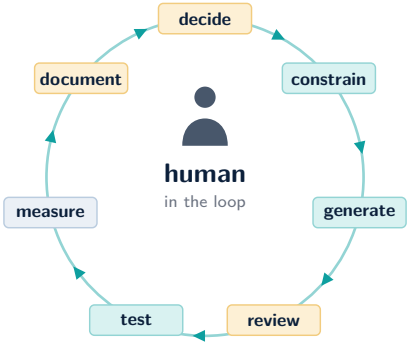
31 decisions

20.48 days error end-to-end

DeepSeek extracted. OpenCode wrote code. I kept the review loop.

AI

- DeepSeek
- OpenCode
- eval scripts



Human

- decide
- review
- gatekeep

BUILD LOG

prompt → 258 days off → extract-only + quotes → six gates

built
on a phone

The checks are what make another person's change defensible.

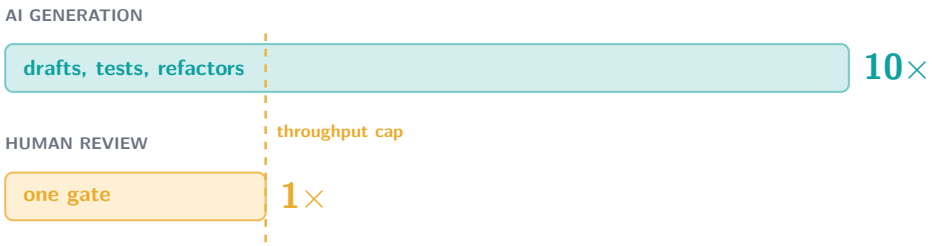
Review before merge

6 checks

- **Contract** — does it match the interface?
- **Failure modes** — empty, None, huge input?
- **Determinism** — same input → same output?
- **Evidence** — can I trace the number?
- **Tests** — fails when I break it?
- **Rollback** — can I revert in one commit?

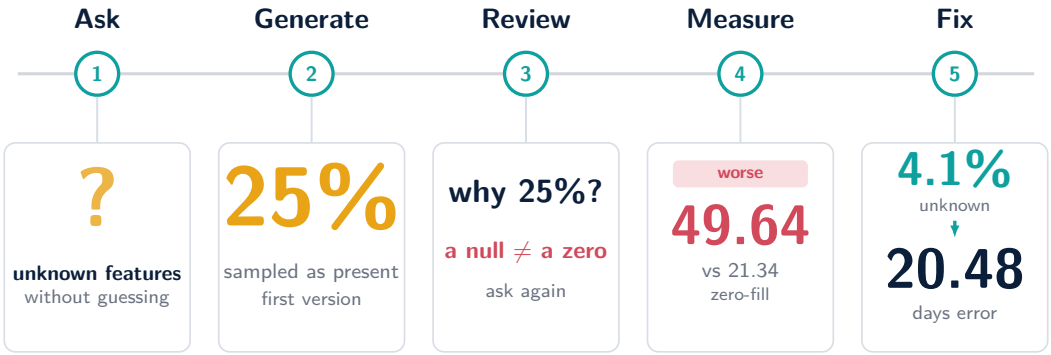
09 · THE BOTTLENECK

The review gate sets the real speed, so that is what I would fix.

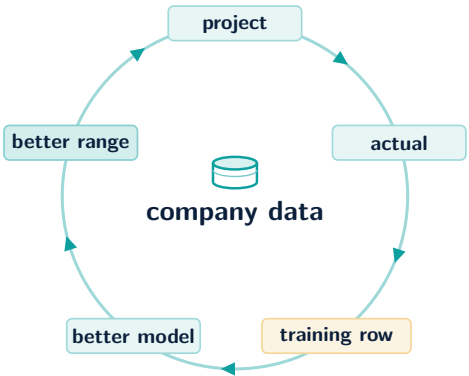


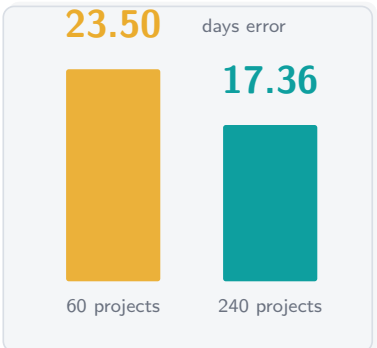
WHERE I INVEST INSTEAD OF PROMPTS

- shared eval set
- same six checks
- small diffs


Ask
1
?
unknown features
without guessing
Generate
2
25%
sampled as present
first version
Review
3
why 25%?
a null ≠ a zero
ask again
Measure
4
worse
49.64
vs 21.34
zero-fill
Fix
5
4.1%
unknown
20.48
days error

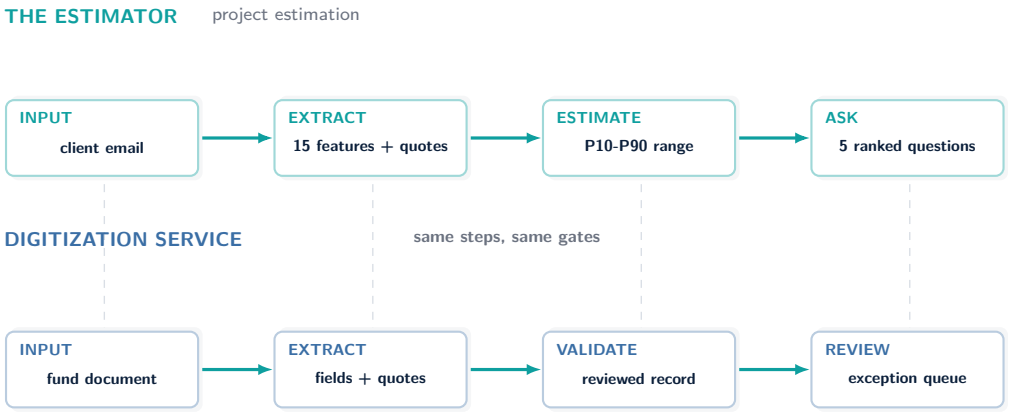
Every finished project becomes a training row: 60 → 240, error 23.5 → 17.4 days.





same model, more history

Document in, fields with evidence, a human clears exceptions.



A baseline, one document type, and a gate at every step.

day 0 — day 14 — day 45 — day 90

01 · DAYS 1-14

Shadow

Time one fund document workflow. Count rework. Inventory automations.

OUTPUT

Baseline minutes per document, rework rate.

GATE

A number, not an opinion.

02 · DAYS 15-45

Ship one slice

One fund document type, end to end. Every field keeps its evidence.

OUTPUT

A tool the Digitization team opens daily; every exception has an owner.

GATE

No unreviewed record leaves the queue.

03 · DAYS 46-90

Measure or kill

Re-run the week-2 baseline. Keep what beats it. Document it.

OUTPUT

Before/after numbers and a one-page playbook.

GATE

Beats baseline, or it stops.

The review is the part I refuse to skip.

shipped

one container, one URL

tested

242 offline tests

honest

5 negative results published

Nguyen My Thong · AI Business Operations

github.com/iknizzz1807/the-estimator

scan for repo